

Modelling Field manual

Companion Guide to the Data Science Deck

Dr. Jemil Avers Butt ¹

A portable manual for researchers: data science deck introduction, operational ruleset, instructive examples. A field guide blending mental and scientific layers of mathematical modelling.

¹With support from Atlas optimization GmbH, www.atlasoptimization.com

Contents

1	Quickstart	1
1.1	Introduction	1
1.2	How to read the booklet	2
1.3	License	3
1.4	First steps	3
2	Manual	5
2.1	Complete Procedure	5
2.2	Materials	6
2.3	Game rules	6
2.4	Game topology	7
3	Discussion [Science + Rules]	9
3.1	The 5 + 1 Domains	9
3.2	Philosophy of modelling	13
3.3	Card placement and game topology	15
3.4	Discussion: Reading the geometry	16
3.5	Discussion: Reading the cards	16
4	Game modes	17
4.1	Example 1: True Tarot (see tab 4.3)	17
4.2	Example 2: Own Worst Enemy	18
4.3	Example game modes	18
4.4	Mode sheet template	22
4.5	Card interpretation examples	22
4.6	Annotated example games	23
5	Narrative introduction	24
	Note to the reader	24
5.1	Welcome to the dig	25
5.2	Story artefacts	28
5.3	The 5 domains	33
5.4	Initiation	38
5.5	Card Interpretations	42
5.6	Conversion	43

6	Cards	45
6.1	Source	45
6.2	Voidframe	48
6.3	Structure	48
6.4	Chameleon	48
6.5	Volition	48
7	Scientific Compendium	49
7.1	How to read this compendium	49
7.2	Source	50
7.3	Voidframe	50
7.4	Structure	50
7.5	Chameleon	50
7.6	Volition	50
7.7	Global glossary (optional)	50
7.8	Global references (optional)	51
	Attachments	52
7.9	Note pages (prompted)	52
7.10	Game mode template	53
7.11	Session log	55
7.12	Indexes	56
7.13	Imprint	57

1 Quickstart

1.1 Introduction

What this deck is

This deck is a compact instrument for structuring thinking. It externalizes the parts of mathematical modelling that are usually implicit: what you model, what you impose, what your model does, what you don't pursue, what you want to achieve.

Thinking about modelling is structured by drawing, placing, and reflecting on cards. These cards are clustered into $5 + 1$ domains that represent different aspects of modelling. The goal is to make your next modelling move easier to see and justify. The deck aims to help you become a better modeller. The full deck consists of two parts:

The base deck

These are ~ 55 cards meant for thinking about modelling and other problems abstractly. They contain the modelling domain overview cards and the full Aspect domain, which represents basic operations of thought.

The extension deck

These are ~ 100 cards that extend the base deck with much more detail about specific phenomena encountered when building mathematical models. Contains the full Source, Structure, Chameleon, Void, and Volition domain cards. Meant for experts and in-depth detailed analyses.

Who this deck is for

Primarily for students, practitioners, and researchers who build, fit, or analyze mathematical models. More broadly, for anyone struggling with converting between the real world and abstract representations. It does not matter whether the modeled phenomena come from the physical sciences, engineering, medicine, econometrics, math, or even art. Whenever an abstraction is built, the same tensions reappear.

The name "Data Science Deck" implies a certain closeness to data science, statistics, and machine learning; for these disciplines it was originally developed and probably fits best.

What this deck is not

This is not a competitive game with strategy, points, and finally winners. A game session is more Tarot and less Poker. The cards do not provide concrete answers. There is no system that maps cards to a conclusion. Your thinking cannot be replaced.

The deck stays intentionally abstract. You will not find cards "Differential Equation", "Autoregressive Model", "Transformer", or "LSTM". Instead you will find cards on *recursion* and *memory*; you combine these concepts to recreate any specific thing you want.

1.2 How to read the booklet

Layering

Start with section 1.4 for concrete first steps.

The chapter *Manual* (chapter 2) contains procedures, defaults, and game modes.

The chapter *Science* (chapter 3) collects scientific background on modelling themes that cut across domains.

The chapter *Gamemodes* (chapter 4) provides some exemplary gamemodes and example sessions for illustrative purposes. It serves as support when experimenting with different ways to use the cards creatively. The chapter *Narration*

(chapter 5) is a stylistic outlier: a purely narrative entry point.

Finally, the appendices provide practical templates (session logs, mode sheets, and other working pages).

1.3 License

CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

This work (encompassing this booklet and the cards from the Data Science Deck) is licensed under the CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 license. You may copy, share, download, and print this material for personal, educational, or internal noncommercial use, provided you give appropriate attribution. For more detailed licensing information, see the imprint on page 57.

1.4 First steps

A first browse

This is the lowest-friction way to meet the deck. No procedure, no correctness.

- 1) **Fan and skim.** Take any 10–15 cards from anywhere in the deck.
- 2) **Give them some time.** Ask: how could this card be relevant?
- 3) **Keep only what sticks.** Put aside the 2–3 cards that feel “interesting”.

We both know you were going to do this anyway.

A first analysis

This is a fully specified, reproducible first run. No shuffling, no choice: you will use the five Domain Master Cards in a fixed order and apply them to a simple model.

Problem. Straight line $\hat{y} = ax + b$ fitted to measurement

data y .

Setup. Take only the 5+1 Domain Master Cards, i.e. "Source", "Structure", "Chameleon", "Void", "Volition", "Aspect".

Procedure. Read one card at a time in the sequence specified above. For each card, think about its relevance to the above problem and write down one thought.

Example outcomes.

- **Source (S):** What am I modelling? What is the physical reality behind x and y , and their linearity? Where would "noise" come from in this setting? ...
- **Structure (St):** What am I imposing? (Same model $\hat{y}$ for all the data y , two unknown constants a and b , linearity, distribution of $\epsilon = \hat{y} - y$, independence of ϵ , ...).
- **Chameleon (Ch):** What does my model do? (Single input, single output, optimization of a and b , residuals, outlier handling, underfitting, ...).
- **Void (Vd):** What am I not pursuing? (missing input, latent variables, distribution of noise, constraints, nonlinearity, other observations, ...).
- **Volition (V):** What do I want? (Learn something about y , fit a simple model to iterate later, analyze the slope, write nice code, learn about modelling, be done with this tutorial, ...).
- **Aspect (As):** What are the aspects? (This is math, a simple fitting problem, part of the tutorial, could be coded, possibly important for later, ...).

Output. You should end with exactly six bullet points and one clear next move.

2 Manual

2.1 Complete Procedure

Complete Procedure

1. Decide on a problem you want to think about and a gamemode from section 4.3 on p. 18. Recommended: "Standard".
2. Prepare the material according to section 2.2.
3. Draw a card according to the **Drawing rule** and place it according to the **Placement rule**.
4. Think about the card you just placed according to the **Timing rule**.
5. Repeat steps 3 and 4 until the **Closure rule** triggers.

The **rules** mentioned above are defined in section 2.3.

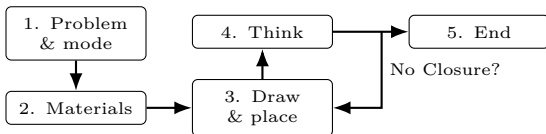


Figure 2.1: Core session loop: Iterate draw/place and think; end anytime; otherwise continue.

2.2 Materials

Materials

- The deck, separated into six face-up domain piles (shuffle each pile) unless the game mode specifies otherwise.
- A flat surface of size at least A3. [Optional]: Label the 5 domain zones (section 2.4).
 - [Optional]: Prepare Session Log (section 7.11, p. 55).
 - [Optional]: Special objects depending on game mode.

2.3 Game rules

Ruleset

- **Topology rule** The game surface is partitioned into domain zones as described in section 2.4.
- **Drawing rule** Draw exactly one card per draw. The domain used for that draw cycles through (S, St, Ch, Vd, V, As) and then repeats.
- **Placement rule** Place a card on the game surface either
 - **upright** (virtue) or **reversed** (pathology) *inside its own domain zone*, or
 - **sideways** as a *modifier*, attached onto any other card.
- **Timing rule** Give each card some time to be relevant, especially the confusing ones.
- **Closure rule** End whenever you want. Formulate at least 1 insight.

Core rule The rules are secondary to insight. The deck is meant to benefit you. Do anything you want.

2.4 Game topology

Topology

The cards are placed according to a spatial logic. There are 6 domains in total. 5 domains (Source, Structure, Chameleon, Void, Volition) deal with mathematical modelling and data science concretely. 1 domain (Aspect) is purely abstract; these cards can only be placed sideways and therefore have no dedicated own space on the board.

The game topology reflects several aspects:

- Source, Volition = the real phenomenon and the modelers will be outside the model.
- Structure and Chameleon = fixed and adaptive part of the model in tension between the two outside domains Source, Volition.
- Void = total space of possible models forming the backdrop of actual model choice.

The board is illustrated in figure 2.2 below.

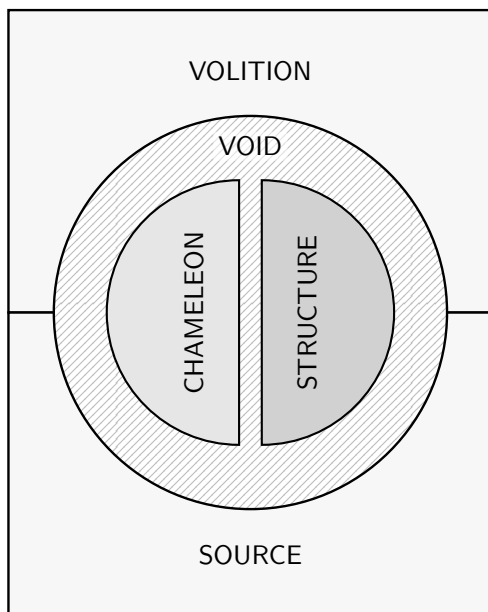


Figure 2.2: The board topology.

3 Discussion [Science + Rules]

3.1 The 5 + 1 Domains

The modelling loop

A session can be understood as iterating a modelling loop through five questions related to modelling and one general reflective question. Going by the fixed domain order $S \rightarrow St \rightarrow Ch \rightarrow Vd \rightarrow V \rightarrow As$ is then a disciplined pass through six questions:

1. **Source (S)**: What is the real world like? ↓
2. **Structure (St)**: What do I impose on the model? ↓
3. **Chameleon (Ch)**: What is the model and how does it behave? ↓
4. **Void (Vd)**: What could the model have been? ↓
5. **Volition (V)**: What is my role and impact? ↓
6. **Aspect (As)**: Which idea do i want to reexamine? ↓

We thereby separate aspects of modelling that are often conflated and not explicitly named (phenomenon, structure, behaviour, limits, decisions). Each aspect builds slightly on the previous one but adds enough own complexity to be warranted its own discussion.

Source (S): Phenomenon comprehension

Source is the world as encountered before it is formalized. Post Naïve but Pre Formal. It is the domain of literature review, field observation, prior knowledge, and situated understanding — the place where phenomena are first approached as things that exist rather than objects to be modeled.

Its function is to prevent “modelling the wrong thing”. Many modelling failures are due to Source being underappreciated in favor of more sophisticated models, therefore the behavior of phenomenon and model drift apart.

Typical Source questions:

1. **Elements:** What is there? (environment, entities, artificial constructions, randomness)
2. **Processes:** What happens? (emergence, propagation, regime change, diffusion, memory effects)
3. **Viewpoints:** From which perspective? (units vs. interactions; instance vs. ensemble; descriptive frame)
4. **Trace:** What do we actually see? (traces, manifestations, regularities, anomalies, chaos, mixture behavior)

Structure (St): Constraints and assumptions

Structure deals with the deliberate imposition of form onto the model. It is architecture, skeleton and prison all in one and often in service to our understanding of **Source**.

Its function is to turn the amorphous expression “a model for X” into something that mimicks in important parts how we expect “X” to behave. Structure is where we inject our knowledge by committing to assumptions and model architecture in service of faithfulness to *Source* and interpretability.

Typical Structure questions:

1. **Ordered Knowledge:** How is it assembled? (distributions, likelihood, priors, hierarchy, factorization)
2. **Instrument of Constraint:** What is enforced? (In-Equality constraints, regularization, logics, invariance, preference)
3. **Architecture of Assumption:** What is assumed? (Un-examined foundations, model correctness, fragility, assumption chains, identifiability)

Chameleon (Ch): Model identity and behaviour

Chameleon is the model as a performer: Its central behavioral patterns, how it adapts to data, how it combines all its elements to create an output. If Structure is the models skeleton and constraint, Chameleon is the modes personality, plasticity and what it does once the lights turn on.

Its function is to fill the frame we outlined manually in Structure with a life of its own. It allows us to talk not only

of the things we designed deliberately but of all the things that just happen. Typical Chameleon questions:

1. **Model Types:** Kind of performer? (Deep, Autoencoding, Multimodal, Probabilistic, Partially fixed, Memory)
2. **Model Components:** What is used? (Inputs, Parameters, Hyperparameters, Latent Variables, Features, Functions, Optimizer)
3. **Model Behavior:** What happens? (Optimization, Generalization, Sparsity, Bias-Variance, Hallucination, Blandness)

Void (Vd): Model boundary and alternatives

Void is everything the model is not. It is not misspecification or pathology, it is absence. This is the domain of the unmodelled, unmeasured, unthought. It is the negative space of modelling made active terrain.

Its function is to clarify the models limits and holes and give a universal background to modelling. It places attention on all possible model designs and thereby allows talking about modelling itself.

Typical Void questions:

1. **Exterior absence** What doesn't enter? (Missing: data, signals, phenomena, intent, diligence)
2. **Interior absence** Where are the holes? (Domain, codomain, expression, explanations, computation)
3. **Void geometry** How does the unmodelled look like? (Uniformity, modelling catalysts, relation to Source and Volition, decomposition, unmodelleable)
4. **Void dynamics** How does modelling happen? (First component, expansion, deletion, exclusion, inversion)

Volition (V): Modelers intentions and decisions

Volition is something personal. It is not the phenomenon or the model, it is the root and pattern of our decisions. Much emphasis is put on objectivity in modelling. But when traced back to its roots, decisions are regularly arbitrary or due

to personal preference. This is hard to model and easy to ignore.

This domains function is to make explicit the impacts that personal psychology and cognition have on modelling. It values introspection and conscious decisions and insists we do not forget that we as modelers have already entered the model as its first latent variable.

Typical Volition questions:

1. **Subliminal**: What happens unconsciously? (Apophenia, defensiveness, ambiguity tolerance, attention allocation, aesthetics)
2. **Cognition** What do I think? (Proxies, rationalization, objective function, narration, model misinterpretations)
3. **Conation** What do I want? (Ethics, goal adaptation, personal impact, personal deficiencies, commitment)
4. **Universal** What does the world want? (Importance redistribution, external influence, irreversibility, trade-offs, paradigms, uncontrollability)

The above 5 domains form a system to reason rather concretely about mathematical modelling, especially in the context of data science. The next domain is an outlier. The following Aspect domain was added in an attempt to have a maximally generalist collection of ways to think about a topic y . The cards are meant to provide concrete operations of thought and are meant to form an abstract basis that even allows recreating the more concrete cards from the 5 domains.

Aspect (As): Abstract aspects of any topic y

Aspect is colorless and unspecific. It is indistinct and only gains meaning once we know which aspect x of which topic y we are investigating. It is not a phenomenon, model, or any object or topic - Aspect does not provide protagonists. Each card is instead a mode of thinking.

This domains function is to allow thinking about any specific topic from many different perspectives. It provides the adjectives to the grammar of objects and actions of the other 5 domains. This additional layer of reflectivity allows asking

how things are. It emphasizes structured and multi-faceted thinking.

Typical Aspect questions:

1. **Framing:** How do I look at it? (Perspective, context, importance, properties, experience)
2. **Configuration** What is it made of? (Relation, partition, law, multiplicity, complexity, randomness)
3. **Passage** How does it change? (Input, output, translation, recursion, transformation)
4. **Difficulty** How does it obstruct? (Absence, ambiguity, fragility, error, limit)
5. **Agency** How do I interact with it? (Stance, actor, decision, preference, conflict)

3.2 Philosophy of modelling

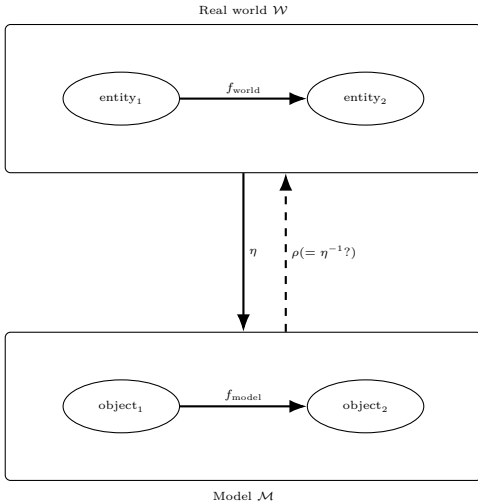
The partition of modelling into the above 5 domains matters. Modelling is an act that aims to balance two apriori unrelated realms: the real world $\mathcal{R}$ and the mathematical world $\mathcal{M}$. Even though we typically aim to represent $\mathcal{R}$ faithfully with a model, in truth a model can be anything.

We could designate a coin flip as a model for gravity. This model is neither forbidden, nor will it collapse internally. It is simply useless for most purposes and that is the metric for a models quality. "All models are wrong, but some are useful." as Box postulates XXXX[].

In that sense a model is a completely separate category from the real world. It has its own objects with its own relations between these objects. Nonetheless, often people performing a modelling task intrinsically try to make the model equal to reality; then think of reality in terms of the model and vice versa. Subsequently, every mathematical property of the model seemingly gives rise to some physical truth: assumptions become natural laws, complex behavior translates to astonishing system insights, and the modeller may cite this depth as a sign for model power. In our words, the **Source** domain gets confused with **Structure** and **Chameleon**, **Void** is never examined as it becomes what the real world supposedly cant do, and **Volition** is quietly ignored

as objectivity is claimed to come from ominous "first principles". We paint here a drastic image, but bad modelling habits do get established quite fast. See e.g. [XXXX] for a compilation and investigation.

Obviously, the hallmark of a good model $\mathcal{M}$ for $\mathcal{W}$ is, is that it emulates important behavior of $\mathcal{W}$. That means that between the $\mathcal{W}$ and $\mathcal{M}$, there is structure preserving map (functor, homomorphism) that allows translating between $\mathcal{W}$ and $\mathcal{M}$ in a limited way. But representation is not free: the choice of what to preserve is an intervention by the modeller—an act of will that later masquerades as inevitability.



In other words, the diagram above is commutative, roughly meaning $f_{\text{model}} \circ \eta = \eta \circ f_{\text{world}}$. If a map η^{-1} with $\eta \circ \eta^{-1} = id_{\mathcal{M}}$, $\eta^{-1} \circ \eta = id_{\mathcal{W}}$ would exist, then $\mathcal{W}$ and $\mathcal{M}$ would be isomorphic and every operation on one could equivalently be carried out on the other.

In practice, this is never the case (exception: model of a model). This is also not the goal of modelling. For being a useful model, it is sufficient that $\rho \circ \eta \approx id_{\mathcal{P}}$ where $\mathcal{P}$ is some interesting subcategory of $\mathcal{W}$. Then instead of analyzing some real-world relation $(e_1 \xrightarrow{f_w} e_2)$, we can instead analyze $\eta(e_1 \xrightarrow{f_w} e_2) = (\eta e_1 \xrightarrow{\eta f_w} \eta e_2) = (o_1 \xrightarrow{f_m} o_2)$ which lies entirely in the model. Some more thoughts can be found in [] XXXX Lawever schanuel and <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/models-science/>? Spivak's Category Theory for the Sciences

Since in practice, we never know all the elements and relations in $\mathcal{W}$, we can check $f_{\text{world}} = \rho \circ f_{\text{model}} \circ \eta \approx id_{\mathcal{P}}$ only with data.

3.3 Card placement and game topology

Board geometry (fixed)

The tableau uses a fixed spatial logic: a vertical axis (Source $\uparrow$ Volition) and a bounded middle (Void) containing two chambers (Chameleon, Structure).

Zones

Volition (top): intent, stance, closure; sends assumptions downward.

Void (centrl background): membrane of knowability; filters and distorts crossings.

Chameleon (left chamber): adaptation, learning, reformulation.

Structure (right chamber): constraints, laws, factorization, invariants.

Source (bottom): phenomena, events, generative causes; sends observations upward.

3.4 Discussion: Reading the geometry

Vertical axis

Bottom → **top** corresponds to *data-to-intent feedback*: Source pressures the model upward; Volition presses assumptions downward.
Interpretively: upward is evidence; downward is framing.

Horizontal split

Left (Chameleon) is flexible and reactive; **right (Structure)** is rigid and stabilizing.
Interpretively: if the center mass shifts left, you are adapting; if it shifts right, you are constraining.

Boundary as instrument

Void is not “nothing”; it is the background that creates the model as an embedded object.
Breaches are the basic events of modeling: observation and assumption crossing into the model space.

3.5 Discussion: Reading the cards

Session log

A log is a compact record that summarizes a session and its insights. For a template, see section 7.11 on page 55

4 Game modes

A mode is specified by (i) a purpose, (ii) a domain status vector, and (iii) procedure. The domain status vector uses the codes below.

Legend (domain status codes)

Domains (order): S St Ch Vd V As (S=Source, St=Structure, Ch=Chameleon, Vd=Void, V=Volition, As = Aspect).

Status codes:

- A = Absent [No cards from this Domain]
- F = Fixed [Cards selected and placed before game start]
- C = Chosen [Cards selected freely during drawing step]
- R = Random [Cards selected randomly during drawing step]

Vector notation: We write status vectors as status codes for [S St Ch Vd V, As]. Example: [R R R R R R] means for all domains the cards are drawn randomly. **Drawing notation:** **rxpy** means reveal x cards from the respective pile, place y, discard the rest. This notation is used only, when the default of drawing and placing a single card is insufficient.

4.1 Example 1: True Tarot (see tab 4.3)

Mode explanation

Domain vector: [S St Ch Vd V As] = [R R R R R R]

Procedure: All placed blindly; reveal + interpret sequentially

What the vector implies & how it plays

Cards from all 5+1 domains are randomized. You draw from S, St, Ch, Vd, V, As sequentially and place the cards blindly according to the laying rules. After a set amount of cards (i.e. 10) you look at the cards and interpret what you see in the context of your problem.

4.2 Example 2: Own Worst Enemy

Mode explanation

Domain vector: [S St Ch Vd V As] = [F C C A C A]

Procedure: Alternate between pro/anti model stance

What the vector implies & how it plays

Cards from Source are selected and placed before game start. Void and Aspect cards are not used at all. You draw from St, Ch, V and choose + place the cards from each domain freely in such a way as to be destructive to the model or salvage it.

4.3 Example game modes

Interpretation

The table below is a library of tested configurations. Each row is a complete mode. Use it as-is, or as a seed for designing new modes by toggling domain states.

Table 4.1: Game modes — I: Idea space traversal

Mode	Purpose		Setup	S St Ch Vd V As	Procedure (short)
Standard	Standard	Experience	Anywhere	C C C C C C	Per draw, look at 5 cards, place 1, discard rest (r5p1)
True Bayes	Free association / brainstorm		Somewhere unexpected	R R R R R R	Draw + place freely; keep tempo high
True Tarot	Surprise, Intuition		Quiet, ritualistic	R R R R R R	All placed blindly; reveal + interpret sequentially
Minimalism	Initial architecture + general		Clean, empty work surface	F F F F F F	Place domain master cards only
Source Review	Understand	phenomen. + literat.	Book, Survey papers	C A A A A R	Fix master cards, then choose/random
Abstraction	Think about arbitrary topic		Bench + representative of topic	A A A A A R	Draw + Combine As cards, make notes
Reverse Auction	Traverse whole idea space		5 draw piles, 5 discard piles	C C C C C A	Fast, reverse: discard irrelevant cards

Legend: Domains listed as S St Ch Vd V, As. A=Absent, F=Fixed, R=Random, C=Chosen.

Table 4.2: Game modes — II: Explore Void and Volition

Mode	Purpose	Setup	S St Ch Vd V As	Procedure (short)
Shadows & Vacuum	Absence / boundary focus	Silent room	F A A C A A	Cards, space, unused deck; draw Vd as (r5p1)
Everything not	Explore model boundaries / alternatives	Empty desk + blank page	A F F R A A	Fix phenomenon, draw absence, explore meaning
Void Cartography	Map the shape of the missing	Cluttered, chaotic desk	A A A R A R	Void geometry/dynamics + Aspect (r5p1).
Ablation Study	Minimal compatible assumptions	Solo, calm workspace	F F F A A A	Fix Source + Model; remove cards till failure
Inheritance	Origins & influence	Anywhere with people	A A A A C A	For each card ask what you inherited
Entropy Auction	Prioritize plurality (group)	Group table	R R R R R R	Each argues why their card matters most

Legend: Domains listed as S St Ch Vd V, As. A=Absent, F=Fixed, R=Random, C=Chosen.

Table 4.3: Game modes — III: Connect to Model and Source

Mode	Purpose	Setup	S St Ch Vd V As	Procedure (short)
Model Archeology	Examine past projects	Desk + old notes	F C C C C R	Recreate chronologically, As (r5p1)
Model Lies	Diagnose deception	Solo, calm desk	R F F R R R	Fix model + data; draw challenges, justify
Model Dies	Stress-test a model	Solo, dim light	C F F C C A	Fix model; draw destructive cards
Own Worst Enemy	Be model & problem	Solo, reflective	F C C A C A	Alternate between pro/anti model stance
Midnight Calibration	Failure under exhaustion	After midnight, candle	R R R R R R	Half-closed eyes; interpret every 2nd card
Exam Clock	Decision under pressure	Desk, strict timer limit	F C C C F A	Fix problem, choose model; grade it
Painter's Trace	Nonverbal conversation into form	Table + pen	A C C C A A	Few cards per domain; interpret quick drawing
Bench and Forest	Reconnect with phenomena	Solo outdoors, seated	C A A A A C	Draw few; attach to nearby objects
Landscape	Meaning via external form	Textured table / map	R R R R R R	Place in geography, interpret via topography
Walk in the Park	Think while moving	Outdoor walk	R R R A A A	Interpret environment through cards

Legend: Domains listed as S St Ch Vd V, As. A=Absent, F=Fixed, R=Random, C=Chosen.

4.4 Mode sheet template

How to invent and document a new mode

Specify Mode name, purpose, setup, Domain vector and procedural notes. There are empty mode sheet templates you may fill out or copy in the attachments to this guide, see table in 7.10 on page 54.

Common design logic

Fix Source $\Rightarrow$ Analytical, Modelling a fixed Phenomenon.

Fix Structure / Chameleon $\Rightarrow$ Diagnostic, Investigating a fixed model.

Fix Void $\Rightarrow$ Conceptual, Exploring model space under constraint.

Fix Volition $\Rightarrow$ Intentional, Pushing towards a goal.

With knowledge about the Domains, absence, choice, randomization can be interpreted similarly.

4.5 Card interpretation examples

4.5.1 Single cards

Pair examples (placeholder)

2–4 canonical pairs with short analysis: when they reinforce, when they conflict, what action they suggest.

4.5.2 Card pairs

Pair examples (placeholder)

2–4 canonical pairs with short analysis: when they reinforce, when they conflict, what action they suggest.

4.5.3 Advice / recommendations

Failure modes

Narrative overfitting; confirmation bias; repeated drawing until comfort; confusing Volition with certainty; ignoring follow-up tests.

4.6 Annotated example games

Case template

Question; Spread; Cards drawn; Primary reading; Counter-reading; Next test/action; Outcome; Update.

4.6.1 Example I (placeholder)

4.6.2 Example II (placeholder)

5 Narrative introduction

Note: Optional content

This chapter is an unapologetically narrative artifact: a recovered set of notes, fragments, and stories. It is *optional*. Nothing required for play, rules, or procedure is contained here. If you prefer the deck as a practical companion for introspection, you may skip this chapter without loss.

However, if you want to introduce an additional layer of storytelling and atmosphere to your sessions, please go ahead.

5.1 Welcome to the dig

Journal Entry 1: Arrival

CONFIDENCE: HIGH (LOGISTICAL); MEDIUM (INTERPRETIVE)

We arrived before noon. The access road disappears into scrub so politely that it feels intentional. The university called this a “low-stakes cataloguing expedition,” which is another way of saying: *a gift*, a farewell gesture, a chance to lead without being watched too closely. I am grateful for that. I am also aware that gratitude is how one gets careless.

My team: Cal (student; delighted by every cable and measurement head), and Alex (coworker and old friend; skeptical in the way that is protective but usually useful). Two weeks on site, then back. Lonely, yes, but loneliness is not unfamiliar to archaeologists; it is part of the job description even when you travel in groups.

The underground site is better preserved than the brief promised. Furniture remains in some corners: an ancient cabinet with the doors only incompletely rusted shut, a narrow desk that still looks like work happened on it. The most interesting surfaces are the ones that should not have survived: sketches, symbol chains, repeated marks as if someone had practiced a stroke until their hand learned it. Layout: two half-sphere chambers (true 3D; the floor is a broken bowl you must learn to walk on) wedged between two rectangular rooms, four chambers in total.

Most devices already unpacked, thanks Cal. Alex is already grumbling about the stylistic mismatch between the profound old and all the transient new-tech. While asking Cal for the spare battery and booting up his own set of screens.

We will map, photograph, sample, and leave. That is the official plan.

Unofficially, I want two things: (1) to do good work without burning my hands; (2) to allow whatever is here to resonate enough with us to make for an enriching experience.

It might not be the most exciting excavation site but after the chaos of last year, I know we all need a bit of time off the usual duties and can count ourselves lucky for this opportunity.

Status: Stable

Day one was, pleasantly, just work.

We laid out a simple grid, set targets, and spent an unreasonable amount of time arguing about where “north” should be on the sketch map. Cal unpacked the new scanner and treated every cable like it deserved respect. Alex declared the dust “historic” and then immediately found a way to get it into his coffee.

Lunch was tins and bread on the one intact table. We sat on the floor because the stools were either missing or suspicious. Someone (Cal) had brought a little roll of painter’s tape, and by mid-afternoon every tripod leg, sample bag, and power brick had a tiny label. It made the place feel briefly like a normal lab, just with worse lighting and better acoustics.

In the afternoon we did the first pass of photographs and surface rubbings. The spherical rooms are annoying in a very ordinary way: echoes are hard on voice memos, and the floor is a mess of rubble that punishes inattentive ankles.

Alex stared at the broken bowl of the floor for a full ten seconds, as if it might rearrange itself out of politeness. Then he said, almost respectfully, “Somebody built this and thought: yes. This will teach them humility.” Cal laughed, then offered him a hand like it was obvious. Alex took it, and for the rest of the pass they moved like that. Alex slipping, Cal steadying him, both pretending it was normal. I had the brief, pleasant sense that this was what fieldwork really is: a series of small rescues that don’t get written up. “Don’t document this,” Alex said. I documented it.

Cal then demonstrated the new scanner. “Wait—no—look,” he said, and the mesh resolved a hidden cavity behind a wall panel. Nothing inside, though. Just space. Would have been too nice to get a breakthrough for free on the first day.

We finished the day tired, dusty, and in good spirits. I slept unusually well.

Journal Entry 2: Translation Success

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM

This took less time than expected. After one more day of gathering paired inscriptions (thanks, Cal), we distilled a small Rosetta stone: repeated symbol chains paired with pictorial contexts, plus a few sequences that appear in both “formal” and “casual” locations.

The language is low-complexity—good news. Less will be lost in grammar quirks; more will be lost in density. Entropy estimate: unusually high. The texts waste nothing. I prefer this to the improbable, never-ending redundancies of first-year decipherment exercises. Still: density is how a document hides traps in plain sight.

Entry headline translation

The first sentence we translated was the one written above the entry tunnel; it is either invitation or warning:

Abandon all certainty, you who enter the 5 domains.

It speaks of *five*, yet we have only four chambers. I have checked the map twice. Alex checked it a third time and pretended he wasn’t checking it.

Plates found

We found multiple tin boxes of plates. Each box appears to have been stored in a different chamber, in a different manner of reverence: the top of some type of specimen cabinet, a locked ornate box (do not ask how we opened it), a sliding door cabinet, and just in the open out on a notice board. Odd etchings. Repeated motifs and symbols - these will be interesting to decipher. Some fragments cross-reference each other by phrase, as if recited.

Status: Stable (for now)

5.2 Story artefacts

Stories with a common element

We tried out the translation key immediately. I have to admit I am positively surprised at the coherence of the results though their meaning stays oblique. I have compiled below 3 of the stories that seem to be centering around some type of ritual card game.

Artefact 1a: Three Soldiers in a Ruined City

They did not light a fire even though they were cold. Fire is a signal, and a signal is a promise to be seen.

They sat in a stairwell with a lantern turned so low it was almost nothing. Tomorrow there would be a battle, not the glorious kind, the kind that becomes mud.

"The bricks listen," said the oldest, and the youngest laughed because that is what you do when you are terrified.

They did not draw for victory. They drew to name the shape of their uncertainty to keep it from eating them alive.

One card was placed on the rubble. A second card beside it, upside down. The lantern dimmed as if ashamed.

When the third card appeared, it was the mirror crossing the first one like a wound. They hugged silently. Trying to remain human while the world turned them into arithmetic.

Geometry and pattern

Placement is described but not explained (upside down/crossing). This resembles a spatial grammar.

Artefact 1b: Three Girls at the Tavern

It was midnight, and the pub was closing with the slow mercy of tired people. Three girls argued softly about who would get a boyfriend first; to them love was a race and the finish line a joke.

"It will be me," said the first, and she said it like a dare. "No," said the second, "it will be her," and pointed, because teasing is safer than wishing. The third rolled her eyes, then reached into her coat and produced a small bundle wrapped in cloth.

They laughed. They drew. They mocked the words on the cards like children mock prayers.

Then the second girl went quiet so suddenly that even in their half-drunk state the other two noticed immediately. "That's not fair," she said, and her voice had no joke left in it. "That isn't what I asked."

"You asked," said the third, almost gently, "what you ask when you say you ask something else."

Outside, in the street, a couple argued in whispers. Inside, the cards lay between the girls like a small, polite disaster.

They did not speak of boyfriends again. They spoke of leaving. They spoke of their mothers.

A repeated motif

Again: laughter stops, or a room falls quiet, precisely when someone realizes they asked the wrong question. The text treats that realization as sacred, though it never uses that word.

Artefact 1c: The Mechanic's Calibration

The instrument lied by a little, and the little was the

problem. Big lies are easy. You throw the instrument away. Little lies get you killed slowly.

That is the dangerous kind: the kind that passes your first check and then fails your second, and then you blame your hands, and then you blame the room, and then you get tired.

I cleaned the contacts. I warmed the unit. I set the reference. I did the things you do when you want to say you were responsible.

The first measurement said: good. The second said: good. The third said: good.

I started to relax. That is how it always happens. How the willingness to lie announces itself. That damn relief.

So I drew a card before I allowed myself to stop. It was the card that warns of will bent. It did not tell me what the truth was. But it did tell me what I was doing: I wanted to be done rather than right.

So I continued the measurements. Like a grin, the fourth said: not good.

I committed, out loud, to one more cycle. I seek not comfort, but correction. If the residual persists, it is not noise. If it stays, it is structure. Either way I will learn something.

The next one was Backstage Mechanism. I hate that name because it feels like theater, but the meaning is plain: there is a state you are not tracking, and it is impacting your observations.

So I stopped treating each measurement as identical. I introduced a latent state: temperature after warm-up, clamp pressure, the order of operations—pick your poison. I wrote it down as a variable I could not see but could infer and split the runs by that state.

Then the instrument did what instruments do when you finally speak to them honestly: it became simple.

When I put the unit back into service, I felt tired in a clean way.

Comfort or Correction

I note again a devotion to truth and an aversion to comfort. Similar to “the bricks listen” in the first story. It seems a strange mnemonic for: *assume you are being observed by reality itself.*

Insight 1: Ritual Divination

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM

These three fragments are not isolated. We have a cluster: short narratives where cards are handled as ritual instruments.

The aim is not prediction in the childish sense. The aim is to make uncertainty speak in a structured way: future, secrets, impossibilities, the boundaries of what can be claimed. I suspect the ritual served a civic function: it allowed people to talk about fear without naming it as fear.

Alex's objection

Alex brought up an alternative. That it allowed them to feel in control when they weren't. Which is possible. But the fragments are unusually hostile to comfort. They mock the reader who draws again until a pleasing answer appears or stops afraid of what might be revealed. They praise fighting ignorance as much as admitting it.

Cards = Plates

Several symbol chains in these stories match the etchings on the plates we found in these chambers yesterday one-to-one. I think this is too much of a coincidence to ignore. After discussion with Cal and Alex, we agree that the cards

from the stories are with high probability the aforementioned plates. Consequently I will not distinguish between cards and plates in the remainder of these notes.

Status: Stable

Journal Entry 3: Decision to Investigate

CONFIDENCE: HIGH (DECISION); LOW (CONSEQUENCES)

I decided we will invest time into clarifying the ritual. It is rare to find ritual tools *with* the space that housed them. We have plates, walls, inscriptions, furniture, and enough continuity to reconstruct behavior.

Cal asked why this matters. I gave him the chain I always give students, because it is true: living conditions → necessity + psyche → ritual. We have the ritual. If we understand it, we backpropagate insight into their reality. Also: shifting perspective is a kind of hygiene. It refreshes the mind the way the different climate here refreshes the lungs.

He nodded, then asked if the ruins could have been used by ordinary people, not an elite. He wants the ritual to be democratic. That is a good instinct.

Target Audience

If the stories are genuine, then this is not a tool for the clergy. The almost universal preclusions of certainty do not lend themselves well to any doctrine. It would have rather belonged among surveyors diagnosing device errors, tradespeople on their way to the next city, scholars who could not say aloud what they feared. It is portable. It is private. It is, in places, almost tender.

Alex made me laugh again. “Ann, if this turns into you starting a cult in a cave, I’m filing a complaint.”

We all agreed more easily than I expected. Cal likes tools. Alex likes meaning. I like both. I hope we can keep it this harmonious.
Status: Stable

5.3 The 5 domains

Naming and meaning

We recovered an interesting text that brings some cohesion to the different entities recurring in the stories. I suspect, these entities are zones of thought rather than actual mythic figures. On the surface: a traveler, half-hallucinating, meeting a sequence of entities by firelight. Underneath: a brace that binds the scattered aspects of thought into one spine. The original text begins without title, I have dubbed it "The Fireside Story" for reference purposes.

Artefact 2: The Fireside Story

On the third night the Framer stayed awake by a low fire and thought it was dying. The smoke bent upward and refused the trees. The sky answered.

A bird landed on their shoulder—raven, or owl, or something that wore those names loosely—and dropped a single warm seed into their palm. They tried to speak. Nothing came out.

They understood nonetheless: Source is not benevolent, not cruel, not even interested. It precedes any story told about the world, and will be the one thing left once the fire has died. They put the seed in their pocket like a debt not to be paid.

Hours later the fire spat once, and something heavy stepped out of the dark to strangle the fire. A prison made of staircases broken mid-step, of brickwork and iron lattices. A floor-pattern of spirals and arcs,

ordered enough to hurt. The pattern flickered and became a key—brass, cold, heavy as regret. The Framer understood the way a lock teaches understanding: by closing. Structure is not sanctuary. It is a room you mistake for safety until you test the door.

Within the fire itself, something would not hold still. Fluttering with shifting masks, open mouths, and patched robes, every attempt to grasp it made it bend back into something unrecognizable. Then the thing was no longer in the flames. Howling, then laughter came from the dark now. The sound a thing makes when it learns it can become whatever it wants. The Chameleon left two of its many faces behind as a gift for freeing it. Adaptation survives – even the best intentions. It does not stop feeding just because you are safe.

After that, no figure arrived. One more went away instead. Leaving only absence in its wake. Marks in the dirt smeared into nothing. The edge of the firelight pulled inward. A broken mirror crawled from the ash, reflecting nothing, absorbing everything. It was not emptiness. It was full to bursting of the dead questions it devoured. It was all the fire was not, and it was so, so cold.

The fifth did not arrive from outside. It rose in their own chest as realization set in. Even when the Void took everything, one thing still remained. And it had a name and a face. Volition left no token, only a sentence in the ashes:

What do you want me to say?

At dawn the Framer stood. Carrying with dirty fingers the seed, the key, the masks, the mirror, and the knowledge that the fifth visitor had been present all along.

Journal Entry 4: Investigation into the Five

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM

On Numbering and Naming

We found only four chambers, and yet the recovered texts all insist on five domains. The fireside story however helps us out by making names (and to a considerably lesser degree meaning) more concrete.

I sent Cal to compile the most explicit wall-texts from each chamber into crisp descriptions. He returned tired and pale.

The missing one—the fifth—is everywhere and nowhere. He found only fragments of it: on doorways, in corridors, on thresholds. He said (and he seemed embarrassed to say it): “wherever I went, I only felt it had been there just before i came.” He used the phrase *perspective slipping*. He took a break without being told. Good.

Introduce healthier habits

I reminded myself to take breaks too. Artificial light and stone walls can do tricks on the mind. As much as I praised Cal for stopping when he did, I need to extend that same courtesy to Alex and myself.

Status: Unstable (mild)

Insight 2: The Five Domains Contextualized

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM (INTERPRETIVE)

In the recovered text fragments, these domains are not categories of cards. They are a way of carving experience into five recurring aspects that appear whenever people try to understand or act.

If I strip away the aesthetics, what remains is a workflow: a disciplined cycle that forces the mind to visit five stations it otherwise balances extremely unevenly. In modern terms it resembles a loop: phenomenon → constraint → adaptation → boundaries → introspection, and then on to the next cycle.

Source

Source is the encountered world *before* it becomes a formal object. That does not mean conceptual naivety, though. It is: nature, terrain, people, machines, emergence, growth, dissolution - all the things that produce the data we might perceive. It is where we learn what the phenomenon *is* when we lay down our notebook and try to grasp it with our hands and smell it. Only afterwards do we decide what to measure and which arrows drawn with pen and paper are meaningful. When Source is missing or misinterpreted, we do not notice in our thoughts or in our heart — we notice by the tunnel collapsing or the machine exploding. Source cares nothing for our theories.

Structure

Structure is the hardening of knowledge into form. It is the part of thought that asserts priority, constraint and impossibility. Without it thought stays an amorphous cloud of uniform possibility incapable of decisive prediction that adheres to the rules of our choosing wherever these may be derived from. As such structure is both stiffness and the price we pay for clarity.

Chameleon

Chameleon is plasticity under evidence: the ability to adapt to accomodate different form and behavior. It governs learning and revision, but also seduction: overfitting to spurious patterns with the consequence our thoughts becoming indistinguishable from the observations we digested - until a new observation reveals this catastrophic failure in generalizability. Chameleon is where the thoughts become a living thing: they update, drift, mask, and sometimes lie beautifully. Chameleon is the domain that keeps Structure from hardening into ideology and Source from remaining mute.

Void

The Void is absence as presence. It is the negative space of thinking recognized as active terrain. Absence is not a defect; its *structure* is as real as that of existing hypotheses: what we did not measure, what we cannot name, what we excluded to make the problem solvable, what we forgot we excluded. Void appears as a mismatch between the questions we want to ask and what our thoughts can answer as well as the feeling that our clean diagram is casting a shadow in which monsters may hide. Nonetheless it is not the domain of failures, it is the domain that prevents unwitnessed absence becoming the delusion of certainty.

Volition

Volition is the domain of recognizing the self as an actor and the primal source of thought and decision. It is less the description of a thought model and more the realization of the patterns that formed it. The larger landscape of actors, their emotions, their cognition, and their will forms the often overlooked backdrop against which all thought happens. Where Volition is unacknowledged, self awareness darkens and all that has been formalized is mistaken for objectivity. The self ignores its own impact.

What the ritual seems to do is not mystical: it is procedural. It externalizes a problem (onto a surface), upon which it forces coverage across five zones of thought (geometrically separated), and gives a unified grammar for structured analysis (the cards). This seems to hold even for people who do not share the same intuition as it names concepts and gives them a physical spatial presence. This replaces the awkwardness of discussing about abstract concepts whose internal representations differ from person to person by referencing as external anchor "the card" which provides some measure of objectivity, geometry, and shared intuition.

Practically, in a team, one can point to Void and say "there is something in the model that we dont understand" without having to win an argument. One can point to Structure and Chameleon and say "this constraint is too violent and we witness this as

bland degeneracy” without abandoning rigour or adaptivity. One can point to Volition and say “I worry about this decision due of exterior pressures” and watch the conversation become honest. Forcing abstract discussions out of individual nonaligned brains and into a shared physical space in which ideas have permanency and synchronicity does sound intriguing.

Similarities to Tarot

The ritual uses the domains the way Tarot uses archetypes: as permission to speak in a guided manner but nonetheless freely. But the resemblance ends quickly. Tarot tends to interpret a life. This apparatus tends to interpret a *problem*: how you have framed it, what you have bound, what you have allowed to change, what you have ignored, and what you are committing yourself to.

I now think the deck functioned as a portable “thinking instrument” for communities that had too much uncertainty and too few formal tools to hold it.

If the practice truly was widespread as the stories indicate, then this was not a game with winners. It was a portable technology of introspection: a socially acceptable way to face uncertainty without being devoured by it.

Alex brings up that a less romanticized description could be that reading the deck was a learned habit to ritualize indecision and offload responsibility to justify helplessness. I think this is a valid objection and there might be a real risk of this happening for the uninitiated. Yet the fragments praise commitment when commitment is demanded and they praise stopping when stopping is the only honest act. To me that sounds not like indecision. It is disciplined hesitation.

Status: Stable

5.4 Initiation

Artefact 3: Some notes on Initiation

Initiation notes

In some of the stories the Initiation to the deck is described in less than romantic terms. In light of the fatigue we are facing I instructed Cal and Alex to steer clear of this type of source material. I record here one especially troubling account in which the author describes a “conversion” from deterministic thinking to probabilistic thinking as if it were an infection.

I used to believe that if you knew enough, you could be certain. I used to believe the world owed you an answer if you asked the question correctly. I used to believe that error was a stain you could scrub away.

But I met them.

The first time they made me say prior out loud, it felt like superstition. The second time, it felt like honesty. The third time, it felt like I was admitting something in court.

They spoke as if certainty were a child that dies of neglect. There is horror in it. In realizing that the crisp line between yes and no was a story you told yourself to sleep.

They say: do not ask to be comforted. They say: ask to be corrected. Sometimes I miss the old simplicity so much I want to scream.

At home I tried to explain it to my sister and she looked at me as if I had joined a theater troupe. When I insisted, she looked at me as if I had joined a funeral.

My father asked me what I believe now. He did not understand. He looked at me as if I had been replaced.

Perhaps I have.

Caution (personal)

I find myself resisting the text and rereading it anyway. I tell myself I am studying a cultural artifact. Yet I have begun to notice how often I reach for certainty as comfort. That recognition is—unpleasant.

Journal Entry 5: Card Translation (and the First Game)

CONFIDENCE: HIGH (TRANSLATION COUNT); LOW (WHAT WE DID)

Translation continues smoothly. Twenty plates already mapped with high confidence. They are the less abstract ones; the rest remain stubborn in spite of lexical clarity. We understand each word and still do not understand the sentence. Alex suggested we try the ritual. Not for belief. For phenomenology: to see how it feels when performed.

I documented what happened, for posterity, and because I do not trust my memory when I am unsettled.

Personal opinion

I include this to show the mechanism by which the deck becomes practice. These are not instructions. They are a record of our own failure to remain observers.

Artefact 4: The First Game

We used a desk lamp turned low and made some coffee that went cold. The question we thought we had was tidy. I shuffled, then drew.

We drew one for Source: The People. For Structure: The Broken Tower. For Chameleon: The Deep One.

It was too perfect: us, this place, and the act of digging. Perfection is a suspicious property.

Then we drew a plate we did not recognize. A mirror showing an inverted sky.

We stared at it blankly until Cal gasped.

“Wait—no—look,” he said, and for once it was not about a device screen. “I know where to look for the missing plates. Not in the rooms. In the walls. In the doors. Where there is nothing else than the bricks and then they stop pretending.”

He left before I could tell him to take a lamp.

I drew the fifth for Volition: You have chosen.

I did not understand it. I did not like it.

Journal Entry 6: Discovery

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM

Cal found the missing tin box in a cavity at the central connection between the two spherical rooms. A space that is not a room. A space that should not have held anything.

Alex does not like it. He says the practice seeps into the brain. He says it makes us question determinism the way damp makes stone soft: slowly, inevitably, without permission.

He is right to be cautious. We should not learn to enjoy uncertainty for its own sake. Tomorrow we will take a break.

The Void cards

The new cards are saturated with mirror motifs and an algebraic notation that I can only approximate as:

$$\mathcal{U} = \mathcal{M} \cup \mathcal{V}, \quad \mathcal{V} = \mathcal{M}^c.$$

Cal laughed when I wrote it down. Alex did not.

Status: Unstable

5.5 Card Interpretations

Insight 3: Card Polymorphism

CONFIDENCE: LOW (OBSERVATIONAL)

The plates are polymorphic. Depending on placement and context they mean almost anything, and yet the “almost” matters: they are productively meaningful more often than chance would allow.

I suspect this is deliberate. Abstract enough to adapt; structured enough to constrain. They open more avenues of thought than they close.

That is exhausting. Also: that may be the point.

Status: Stable

Artefact 5: One Card, Multiple Interpretations (The Broken Tower)

Virtue (upright). A modular tower of assumptions upon which to rest your thoughts. A critical evaluation of your foundational beliefs, finally strengthening the foundation. A mercy, but in disguise.

Pathology (reversed). A mismatched edifice of assumptions that is bound to shatter, noise amplified to ruin. What you thought is the bedrock was just another layer of incorrect thought and a single crack becomes your downfall.

Modifier (sideways). Arrange your constructions in order of fundamentality, then imagine error propagating from the most basic one. Clarify, what would be necessary for catastrophe.

5.6 Conversion

Journal Entry 7: Conversion

CONFIDENCE: HIGH (FACT)

I returned the tin case to our archive shelf and locked it. Then I unlocked it again.

I have cataloged stranger objects. I have handled bones, rusted instruments, letters written in panic. None of them asked me to participate. This one does.

I do not think of it is a religion or a cult. I think it is a posture toward uncertainty that can spread from person to person the way fear spreads—except it does not make you smaller. It makes you precise.

Tonight I will keep it near my bed, like a tool, or like a threat.

Even if this is just a collection of stories and images, this deck is dangerous in a useful way.

I will carry it.

Status: Stable

Journal Entry 8: Tunnel Collapse

CONFIDENCE: HIGH (FACT); UNKNOWN (EVERYTHING ELSE)

A deep rumbling woke us. The entry tunnel has collapsed. With the tools we have, digging ourselves out is not realistic. The university will send someone soon anyway. I am sure at least about this.

We finished translating the rest of the plates. I have attached my notes. In the meantime, I initiated Alex and Cal to perform the reading ritual themselves.

Perhaps we can brainstorm a way out. Perhaps we can endure.

So far I keep drawing: *Mirror In, Mirror Out, Will of the World, The Outlier*. Not encouraging.

Alex asked if I was joking. I did not answer quickly enough.

“Correlation $\neq$ omen.” (Alex wrote this, then scratched it halfway

5 Narrative introduction

out.)

Status: Not stable

6 Cards

6.1 Source

(Card Name)

(SUBDOMAIN)

Scientific Twin: (Scientific Twin)

Mythic layer

Half-page mythic explanation in Fivefold Flame context.

Recognition

Name, domain glyph, subdomain, optional B/W thumbnail (later).

Scientific Twin

Definition and framing.

Core Mechanism

Theory (compact).

Example

A concrete example (research / modeling / decisions).

Field Notes

Practical advice; failure modes; what to watch for.

References

1–3 references max (placeholder).

6.2 Voidframe

6.3 Structure

6.4 Chameleon

6.5 Volition

7 Scientific Compendium

7.1 How to read this compendium

Purpose

Cross-cutting reference: concepts grouped by domain, not by card.

7.2 Source

7.2.1 Core concepts

7.2.2 Glossary (domain-local)

7.2.3 References (domain-local)

7.3 Voidframe

7.3.1 Core concepts

7.3.2 Glossary (domain-local)

7.3.3 References (domain-local)

7.4 Structure

7.4.1 Core concepts

7.4.2 Glossary (domain-local)

7.4.3 References (domain-local)

7.5 Chameleon

7.5.1 Core concepts

7.5.2 Glossary (domain-local)

7.5.3 References (domain-local)

7.6 Volition

7.6.1 Core concepts

7.6.2 Glossary (domain-local)

7.6.3 References (domain-local)

7.7 Global glossary (optional)

Glossary (placeholder)

If you prefer one global glossary instead of per-domain glossaries.

7.8 Global references (optional)

References (placeholder)

Later: biblatex + .bib. For now keep compact manual lists.

Attachments

7.9 Note pages (prompted)

Session prompt

Date; Question; Context; Spread; Cards; Primary reading; Counter-reading; Next test/action; Outcome; Update.

7.10 Game mode template

Field	Entry
Mode name	
Purpose	
Setup	
Domain vector	$[S \ St \ Ch \ Vd \ V \ As] = [\quad \quad \quad]$
Procedure	
Notes	
Outcome	

Field	Entry
Mode name	
Purpose	
Setup	
Domain vector	$[S \ St \ Ch \ Vd \ V \ As] = [\quad \quad \quad]$
Procedure	
Notes	
Outcome	

Attachments

Field	Entry
Mode name	
Purpose	
Setup	
Domain vector	[S St Ch Vd V As] = []
Procedure	
Notes	
Outcome	

Field	Entry
Mode name	
Purpose	
Setup	
Domain vector	[S St Ch Vd V As] = []
Procedure	
Notes	
Outcome	

7.12 Indexes

7.12.1 Card index by domain/subdomain (placeholder)

7.12.2 Index by scientific twin category (placeholder)

Indexing (later)

Optional: imakeidx for an actual index; for now keep manual indices.

7.13 Imprint

Title: Modelling Field Manual — Companion Guide to the Data Science Deck

Author: Dr. Jemil Avers Butt

Year: 2026

Publisher / Rights holder

© 2026 Dr. Jemil Avers Butt. All rights not granted under the license below are reserved.

Support

This project was supported by Atlas optimization GmbH.

Contact (rights, permissions, commercial licensing)

Atlas optimization GmbH

Buchserstrasse 65, c/o Dr. Jemil Avers Butt

5000 Aarau, Switzerland

Email: [info\(at\)atlasoptimization.com](mailto:info(at)atlasoptimization.com)

Tel.: +41 77 268 04 85

Website: www.atlasoptimization.com

License: CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

This work (encompassing this booklet and the cards from the Data Science Deck) is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution–NonCommercial–ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). You may copy, share, download, and print this material for personal, educational, or internal noncommercial use, provided you give appropriate attribution. If you remix, transform, or build upon this material, you may distribute your contributions only under the same license (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0) and you must clearly indicate that changes were made. You may not sell, distribute for profit, or use this work in any commercial product, service, or print run without permission. Commercial licensing is available upon request.

Art and graphic assets

Card front illustrations and background textures were generated with OpenAI's ChatGPT Images (powered by GPT-Image-1.5

/ gpt-image-1.5).¹ Plaques, frames, icons, and layout elements were created by the author using Inkscape (www.inkscape.org) or Scribus (www.scribus.net), unless explicitly credited otherwise.

Rights statement

Copyright © 2026 Dr. Jemil Avers Butt. To the extent that copyright and related rights subsist in the AI-generated images, the compilation, selection, graphic design, and all original vector assets (icons/plaques) are claimed by the author. All rights not granted under the license stated in this booklet are reserved.

Positioning

Atlas optimization GmbH develops optimization and machine learning services and provides consulting, software, and courses. The Data Science Deck is an educational/creative tool for structured thinking and reflection in mathematical modelling. Check out their professional offerings: www.atlasoptimization.com.

¹<https://openai.com/index/new-chatgpt-images-is-here/>